

**MOUNT KENYA UNIVERSITY**

**SCHOOL OF SOCIAL SCIENCES**

[DEPARTMENT OF .....]

**REGULATORY ALIGNMENT AND STRATEGIC SUSTAINABILITY OF  
CLIMATE FUNDS IN DEVOLVED GOVERNANCE: A CASE STUDY OF  
NANDI COUNTY, KENYA**

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the Requirements for the Award of the Degree of Master of [Public Policy and  
Administration] of Mount Kenya University

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## DECLARATION

This concept paper is my original work and has not been presented for a degree or any other award in any other university.

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### **Supervisor's Approval**

This concept paper has been submitted with my approval as the University supervisor.

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## **ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS**

|         |                                                            |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| CCCF    | County Climate Change Fund                                 |
| CCIS    | County Climate Institutional Support (FLLoCA grant window) |
| CCRI    | County Climate Resilience Investment (FLLoCA grant window) |
| CIDP    | County Integrated Development Plan                         |
| CVI     | Content Validity Index                                     |
| FLLoCA  | Financing Locally-Led Climate Action Program               |
| IPCC    | Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change                  |
| KNBS    | Kenya National Bureau of Statistics                        |
| MoALF   | Ministry of Agriculture, Livestock and Fisheries           |
| NACOSTI | National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation |
| PFM     | Public Finance Management                                  |
| SPSS    | Statistical Package for the Social Sciences                |
| UNEP    | United Nations Environment Programme                       |
| WCCPC   | Ward Climate Change Planning Committee                     |

## OPERATIONAL DEFINITION OF TERMS

**Climate fund:** A dedicated, ring-fenced pool of public money, established in law, from which a county finances climate change adaptation and mitigation actions. In this study it refers to the Nandi County Climate Change Fund and the related FLLoCA grant flows that pass through it.

**Devolved governance:** The system of government created by the Constitution of Kenya, 2010, in which political, administrative and fiscal authority is shared between the national government and 47 county governments.

**Regulatory alignment:** The degree to which a county's climate finance laws, regulations, plans and practices are consistent with, and actually comply with, the national legal framework, chiefly the Climate Change Act, 2016 (as amended in 2023), the Public Finance Management Act, 2012 and the County Governments Act, 2012.

**Strategic sustainability:** The ability of a county climate fund to keep financing locally prioritised climate actions over time, measured by the predictability of allocations, diversity of revenue sources, continuity of institutions and staff, and the upkeep of the assets it finances after external support ends.

**Institutional arrangements:** The formal structures that govern the climate fund, including the County Climate Change Unit, steering and planning committees, the fund administrator and the Ward Climate Change Planning Committees.

**Resource mobilisation:** The processes by which the county raises money for the climate fund from its equitable share, own-source revenue, conditional grants, development partners and private or green finance sources.

**Locally led adaptation:** Adaptation in which communities and local institutions have real decision-making power over how climate finance is prioritised, designed, delivered and monitored.

## **CHAPTER ONE**

### **INTRODUCTION**

#### **1.1 Background to the Study**

Climate change is no longer a distant threat for most developing countries. It shows up in failed seasons, flash floods, landslides, new crop pests and rising public spending on emergencies. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change reports that the people and systems least responsible for greenhouse gas emissions are among the most exposed to its effects, and that the gap between what adaptation requires and what is being done keeps widening (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change [IPCC], 2022). The United Nations Environment Programme puts the matter bluntly, describing the world as underfinanced and underprepared for adaptation, with the finance needs of developing countries estimated to be many times larger than current international flows (United Nations Environment Programme [UNEP], 2023).

The question of how climate finance reaches the places where climate risks are felt has become central to this debate. For more than two decades, international adaptation finance flowed mainly through national ministries and large projects, and was criticised for being slow, top-down and hard to trace (Khan et al., 2020). The failure to verify whether developed countries met the pledge of mobilising US\$100 billion a year by 2020 added to concerns about transparency and accountability in the climate finance system (Roberts et al., 2021). In response, the principles of locally led adaptation now call for finance that is devolved to the lowest appropriate level, patient and predictable, and governed with real participation of affected communities (Rahman et al., 2023). Devolution, in other words, is increasingly treated as part of the answer to the climate finance problem.

In Africa, climate change threatens economies that remain heavily dependent on rain-fed agriculture. In Kenya, shifts in the timing and intensity of rainfall and rising temperatures have already reduced crop yields, damaged livestock production and weakened household food security (Kogo et al., 2021). The country has responded with one of the more developed climate policy frameworks on the continent. The Constitution of Kenya, 2010 created 47 county governments and assigned them functions that are highly sensitive to climate, including agriculture, county planning, water and soil conservation, and disaster management (Republic of Kenya, 2010). The Climate Change Act, 2016 then required both levels of government to mainstream climate change into their plans and budgets, and the Climate Change (Amendment) Act, 2023 extended this framework to cover carbon markets (Republic of Kenya, 2016, 2023). The Public Finance Management Act, 2012 allows county executives, with

approval of the county assembly, to create special purpose funds, which is the legal basis on which county climate change funds have been set up (Republic of Kenya, 2012b).

Kenya's County Climate Change Fund (CCCF) mechanism began as a pilot in Isiolo, Makueni, Wajir, Garissa and Kitui counties under the Ada Consortium. The pilot counties passed climate change fund legislation, created ward-level climate change planning committees and ring-fenced between one and two per cent of their development budgets for community-prioritised investments, mainly in water, rangelands and livelihoods (Crick et al., 2019). The model was later scaled nationally through the Financing Locally-Led Climate Action (FLLoCA) Program, a results-based programme financed by the Government of Kenya, the World Bank and other development partners. Under FLLoCA, counties qualify for a County Climate Institutional Support (CCIS) grant and a larger County Climate Resilience Investment (CCRI) grant only after meeting minimum access conditions, which include enacting climate change legislation, establishing a climate change unit and committing a share of the development budget to a climate change fund (World Bank, 2021). Regulatory alignment is therefore not a formality. It is the gateway to money.

Nandi County, in Kenya's North Rift region, offers a useful setting for examining how this system works outside the arid counties where the CCCF model was first tested. The county has a population of 885,711 people (Kenya National Bureau of Statistics [KNBS], 2019), six sub-counties and 30 county assembly wards, and an economy built on tea, dairy and maize farming. Its high rainfall and hilly terrain make it a water tower that feeds rivers draining into the Lake Victoria basin, but they also expose it to landslides, floods, soil erosion and erratic seasons (County Government of Nandi, 2023a; Ministry of Agriculture, Livestock and Fisheries [MoALF], 2017). Research in the county has linked climate variability to changes in tea yields in Nandi East (Sitieni et al., 2017) and to the spread of dodder, a parasitic weed that damages tea bushes, with most farmers reporting that long rainy seasons intensify infestation (Mong'o et al., 2025).

Nandi has taken the formal steps the national framework expects. The county enacted climate change fund legislation in 2021, formulated under the Public Finance Management Act, 2012, which commits two per cent of its annual development budget to climate action (FSD Kenya, 2024). As a FLLoCA participant it set up a Climate Change Unit, trained Ward Climate Change Planning Committees and completed a Participatory Climate Risk Assessment in 2023 through ward-level community engagement and a county multi-stakeholder workshop (County Government of Nandi, 2023b). On paper, therefore, the county's climate fund is aligned with national law.

Whether that alignment is deep enough, and whether it will keep the fund alive once FLLoCA's current five-year phase comes to an end, is the concern that motivates this study.

## **1.2 Statement of the Problem**

Kenya's devolved climate finance model rests on a simple promise: if counties put the right laws, institutions and budget commitments in place, predictable money will flow to community-prioritised climate actions. The legal architecture needed to deliver on this promise now exists in Nandi County. The county has a climate change fund law, a two per cent development budget commitment, a Climate Change Unit and ward-level planning committees (County Government of Nandi, 2023b; FSD Kenya, 2024). Ideally, these arrangements should give the county a stable, well-governed fund that continues to finance local adaptation from its own budget long after external grants taper off.

The evidence suggests that the reality may fall short of this ideal. Studies of the pilot counties found that the CCCF model's success depended heavily on external technical and financial support, and that institutionalising the fund within county planning and budgeting was the hardest part of the work (Crick et al., 2019). Research on climate finance coordination in Kenya shows that power dynamics and vested interests often weaken formal arrangements, so that country ownership on paper does not translate into effective coordination in practice (Shawoo et al., 2022). Work on devolution more broadly warns that decentralisation in Kenya has in some cases moved patronage and rent seeking to the county level rather than removing them (D'Arcy & Cornell, 2016), and that local participatory institutions do not automatically give vulnerable groups a voice in adaptation decisions (Omukuti, 2020a). Counties also depend heavily on transfers from the national government, which exposes ring-fenced funds to delays and budget cuts whenever revenue falls short.

If this gap between formal alignment and real sustainability is not understood and addressed, Nandi County risks a familiar pattern: a burst of climate investment while donor-backed performance grants last, followed by stalled projects, dormant committees and a fund that exists in law but not in practice. Communities that invested time in risk assessments and project selection would lose confidence in county climate governance, and the county would remain exposed to landslides, floods and crop losses that are already costly. Existing studies have concentrated on the arid pilot counties and on national-level coordination, and few have examined, in a single high-potential county, how the quality of regulatory alignment relates to the long-term sustainability of

a county climate fund. This study therefore seeks to establish the influence of regulatory alignment on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County, Kenya.

### **1.3 Purpose of the Study**

The purpose of this study is to examine how the alignment of Nandi County's climate finance laws, institutions, resource mobilisation practices and accountability mechanisms with Kenya's national regulatory framework influences the strategic sustainability of the county's climate fund, and to propose measures that would keep the fund viable beyond the current phase of external support.

### **1.4 Research Objectives**

#### **1.4.1 General Objective**

The general objective of this study is to assess the influence of regulatory alignment on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in devolved governance, with specific reference to Nandi County, Kenya.

#### **1.4.2 Specific Objectives**

The study will be guided by the following specific objectives:

- i) To examine the influence of legal and policy framework compliance on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.
- ii) To assess the influence of institutional governance arrangements on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.
- iii) To evaluate the influence of financial resource mobilisation practices on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.
- iv) To determine the influence of community participation and accountability mechanisms on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.

### **1.5 Research Questions**

The study will seek answers to the following questions:

- i) How does compliance with the legal and policy framework influence the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County?
- ii) What is the influence of institutional governance arrangements on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County?
- iii) In what ways do financial resource mobilisation practices influence the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County?

- iv) How do community participation and accountability mechanisms influence the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County?

## **1.6 Research Hypotheses**

The following null hypotheses will be tested at the 0.05 level of significance:

- H 01:** Legal and policy framework compliance has no significant influence on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.
- H 02:** Institutional governance arrangements have no significant influence on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.
- H 03:** Financial resource mobilisation practices have no significant influence on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.
- H 04:** Community participation and accountability mechanisms have no significant influence on the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.
- H 05:** Political and administrative leadership does not significantly moderate the relationship between regulatory alignment and the strategic sustainability of climate funds in Nandi County.

## **1.7 Justification of the Study**

The study is timely for three reasons. First, the FLLoCA Program's current phase is approaching its end, and counties will soon have to show whether their climate funds can stand on their own budgets. Evidence gathered now can still inform county budget and policy decisions before external grants decline. Second, most of what is known about county climate change funds in Kenya comes from arid and semi-arid pilot counties (Crick et al., 2019; Lutta et al., 2025). Nandi is a high-rainfall, agriculturally productive county whose climate risks, revenue base and politics differ from those of the pilots, so its experience adds a missing perspective. Third, the national framework has changed significantly since the pilots, most notably through the Climate Change (Amendment) Act, 2023, and it is not yet clear how well county laws have kept pace (Republic of Kenya, 2023).

### **1.8 Significance of the Study**

The findings are expected to benefit several groups. The County Government of Nandi, particularly the departments responsible for environment, climate change, finance and economic planning, will receive an evidence-based assessment of where its climate finance framework is strong and where it needs amendment, together with practical options for sustaining the fund. The Nandi County Assembly will gain information to guide its legislative and oversight role over the climate fund and its budget allocations.

At the national level, the National Treasury, the Council of Governors and the climate change directorate may use the findings to refine performance conditions and support for counties as the FLLoCA Program transitions. Development partners and civil society organisations working on locally led adaptation will find evidence on what makes devolved climate funds last. Ward Climate Change Planning Committees and community members will benefit from recommendations aimed at strengthening their voice in fund decisions. Finally, the study will contribute to academic literature on climate finance governance and fiscal decentralisation, and will offer a base for further research in other Kenyan counties.

### **1.9 Scope of the Study**

The study will be carried out in Nandi County and will cover all six sub-counties (Aldai, Chesumei, Emgwen, Mosop, Nandi Hills and Tinderet) and the 30 county assembly wards. Content-wise, it will focus on four dimensions of regulatory alignment: legal and policy framework compliance, institutional governance arrangements, financial resource mobilisation, and community participation and accountability, and their influence on the strategic sustainability of the county climate fund. Respondents will be county officials involved in climate finance, members of Ward Climate Change Planning Committees, members of the relevant county assembly committees, and representatives of civil society and community groups. The study will review the period from the 2021/2022 financial year, when the county's climate change fund legislation was adopted, to the 2025/2026 financial year.

### **1.10 Limitations of the Study**

Some county officials may be reluctant to share information about budget execution or audit findings, which they may consider sensitive. The researcher will address this by presenting an introduction letter from the University and a research permit from NACOSTI, guaranteeing confidentiality and using publicly available budget and audit reports to corroborate responses. Some ward committee members may have limited literacy in English; the questionnaire will therefore be translated into Kiswahili and research assistants fluent in local languages will help respondents where needed. As a

single-county case study, the findings may not be fully generalisable to all counties, although the analytical framework can be applied elsewhere.

### **1.11 Assumptions of the Study**

The study assumes that respondents will give honest and accurate answers; that county budget, expenditure and audit records for the study period are available and reliable; and that the county's climate finance institutions will remain in place during the data collection period.

## **CHAPTER TWO**

### **LITERATURE REVIEW**

#### **2.1 Introduction**

This chapter reviews the theories that underpin the study, empirical studies related to each specific objective, the conceptual framework showing the relationship between the variables, and the research gaps the study seeks to fill.

#### **2.2 Theoretical Framework**

The study is anchored on four complementary theories. Institutional theory explains why counties adopt climate finance laws and structures; resource dependence theory explains how funding sources shape sustainability; stakeholder theory explains the role of participation and accountability; and polycentric governance theory explains how the different levels of government interact in managing climate finance.

##### **2.2.1 Institutional Theory**

Institutional theory, associated with Meyer and Rowan (1977) and DiMaggio and Powell (1983), holds that organisations adopt particular structures and rules not only because they are efficient but because they bring legitimacy in the eyes of regulators, funders and the public. DiMaggio and Powell (1983) identified three pressures that make organisations in the same field look alike: coercive pressure from laws and resource providers, mimetic pressure to copy organisations that appear successful, and normative pressure from professional standards. Scott (2014) later grouped these forces into regulative, normative and cultural-cognitive pillars. A key insight of the theory is decoupling: organisations may adopt formal structures to gain legitimacy while their day-to-day practice continues largely unchanged (Meyer & Rowan, 1977).

The theory is relevant to this study because Kenyan counties face strong coercive pressure to adopt climate change legislation, climate change units and fund regulations, both from the Climate Change Act, 2016 and from the minimum access conditions of the FLLoCA Program (World Bank, 2021). Counties also copy the model that the pilot counties developed. The theory helps the study ask whether Nandi's alignment is substantive or merely ceremonial. A county may pass a law and create committees to qualify for grants, yet leave them under-funded or inactive afterwards. The theory's main weakness is that it says little about how organisations secure the resources needed to sustain structures once adopted; resource dependence theory fills this gap. The theory informs the first and second objectives.

### **2.2.2 Resource Dependence Theory**

Resource dependence theory was advanced by Pfeffer and Salancik (1978), who argued that organisations are not self-sufficient and must obtain critical resources from their environment. Whoever controls those resources gains power over the organisation, and organisations try to reduce this dependence by diversifying sources, forming alliances or using political action (Hillman et al., 2009). The theory has since been applied widely to explain how public and non-profit organisations respond to funding uncertainty.

County climate funds in Kenya depend on resources they do not fully control: the county's equitable share from the national government, conditional grants such as the FLLoCA CCIS and CCRI grants, and a modest own-source revenue base. When most of the fund's money comes from one external source with a fixed end date, the fund's survival is at risk once that source ends. The theory therefore predicts that a climate fund with more diverse and more locally controlled revenue will be more sustainable. It underpins the third objective. The theory is less helpful in explaining the role of communities and citizens, which stakeholder theory addresses.

### **2.2.3 Stakeholder Theory**

Stakeholder theory was popularised by Freeman (1984), who argued that an organisation should be managed in the interests of all groups who can affect or are affected by its objectives, not only its owners. Donaldson and Preston (1995) showed that the theory has descriptive, instrumental and normative strands: it describes how organisations behave, predicts that attention to stakeholders improves performance, and argues that stakeholders have legitimate interests that deserve consideration in their own right.

In devolved climate finance, stakeholders include residents of climate-vulnerable wards, ward climate change planning committees, the county assembly, county departments, the national treasury, development partners and civil society. Kenya's Constitution and the County Governments Act, 2012 make public participation a legal requirement in county planning and budgeting (Republic of Kenya, 2010, 2012a). Stakeholder theory suggests that when these groups have genuine influence over how the fund is used and can hold officials to account, they will defend the fund's budget allocation and help maintain the assets it finances. The theory underpins the fourth objective. Its limitation is that it assumes stakeholders can easily be identified and given voice, whereas studies show that participation spaces can be captured by local elites (Omukuti, 2020a).

#### **2.2.4 Polycentric Governance Theory**

Ostrom (2010) argued that climate change, although a global collective action problem, cannot be addressed only through a single global agreement. Instead, many actions taken by multiple, overlapping centres of authority at different scales can cumulatively make a difference, and such polycentric systems encourage experimentation, learning and trust. Kenya's devolved climate finance system is polycentric by design: the national government sets policy and performance conditions, counties legislate and manage funds, and ward committees identify and oversee investments. The theory helps explain the moderating role of political and administrative leadership, since coordination across these centres depends on the willingness of leaders at each level to cooperate. Cheeseman et al. (2016) show that Kenyan governors have been willing to act together to defend county interests against the centre, which suggests that county leadership can either protect or neglect devolved climate funds.

#### **2.3 Empirical Review**

This section reviews empirical studies related to each of the study variables.

##### **2.3.1 Legal and Policy Framework Compliance and Sustainability of Climate Funds**

Crick et al. (2019) documented the experience of the five pilot counties that established county climate change funds in Kenya. Using programme documentation, interviews and case studies, they found that the passage of county climate change fund legislation was critical because it gave the fund a legal home, defined its governance structures and committed a share of the development budget. All five counties institutionalised the fund in their planning and budgeting and committed between one and two per cent of their development budgets. The study, however, was carried out in arid and semi-arid counties with strong external technical support, and it did not measure the relationship between the quality of legal alignment and sustainability statistically.

Kowalczyk and Dorevitch (2024) developed a framework for evaluating local adaptive capacity to the health impacts of climate change using Kenya's County Integrated Development Plans. Applying the framework to county plans, they found considerable variation in how counties addressed climate-sensitive health hazards in their plans. Although the study focused on health, it shows that national requirements to mainstream climate change are applied unevenly across counties, which supports the need to assess the depth of alignment in a specific county rather than assume it. The study relied on document analysis and did not examine budgets or fund performance.

At the regional level, Omukuti (2020b) examined a Global Environment Facility-funded adaptation project in Tanzania and interviewed 47 stakeholders. Most perceived that government control of adaptation finance, justified as country ownership, enabled disproportionate government influence and excluded other stakeholders from decision making. The study shows that formal compliance with ownership principles does not guarantee inclusive or effective use of funds. Its focus on a national project in Tanzania, however, leaves open the question of how these dynamics play out in Kenya's county-level funds.

### **2.3.2 Institutional Governance Arrangements and Sustainability of Climate Funds**

Shawoo et al. (2022) compared climate finance coordination in Kenya and Zambia using semi-structured interviews, policy documents and literature. They found that political factors, including power dynamics, competing framings of climate finance and vested interests, strongly shaped how actors interacted and hampered coordination in both countries, even where the country had greater ownership of the process. The study demonstrates that institutions on paper are not enough; how they operate in a political setting matters. Its focus was national-level coordination, not county funds.

Cheeseman et al. (2016) studied the early years of devolution in Kenya using interviews and political analysis. They found that governors quickly became powerful political actors and were able to act collectively to defend devolved powers against attempts by the centre to claw them back. D'Arcy and Cornell (2016) examined how devolution affected patronage and rent seeking in Kenya and concluded that devolution had not removed these practices but had brought them to the local level, reflecting expectations that it was 'everyone's turn to eat'. Taken together, these studies suggest that county institutions can either protect climate funds or divert them, depending on how they are governed. Neither study, however, addressed climate finance directly.

### **2.3.3 Financial Resource Mobilisation and Sustainability of Climate Funds**

Lutta et al. (2025) mapped the climate finance landscape in four arid and semi-arid counties of Kenya, namely Elgeyo Marakwet, Turkana, West Pokot and Narok, examining the sources, channels and uses of climate-related finance. Their work provides one of the few county-level analyses of where climate money comes from and highlights the importance of tracking climate finance at the county level. The study was descriptive and did not assess how the mix of funding sources affects the longer-term sustainability of county funds.

FSD Kenya (2024) carried out a county green finance assessment of Nandi County. The assessment noted that the county has climate change fund legislation formulated under

the Public Finance Management Act, 2012, which commits two per cent of the annual development budget to climate change, and identified other laws and plans supporting green investment, such as the county's wetlands management law and water master plan. The assessment is valuable as a baseline, but it was not designed as an academic study and did not test the relationship between financing practices and sustainability.

Globally, Khan et al. (2020) reviewed 25 years of adaptation finance through a climate justice lens and concluded that adaptation finance has remained insufficient, unpredictable and weakly governed, with vulnerable recipients having limited say over its use. Roberts et al. (2021) showed that ambiguity over what counts as climate finance made it impossible to verify whether the US\$100 billion pledge had been met. These studies suggest that counties relying on international flows face uncertainty that they cannot control, which strengthens the case for domestic, predictable funding. They did not, however, examine sub-national funds.

#### **2.3.4 Community Participation, Accountability and Sustainability of Climate Funds**

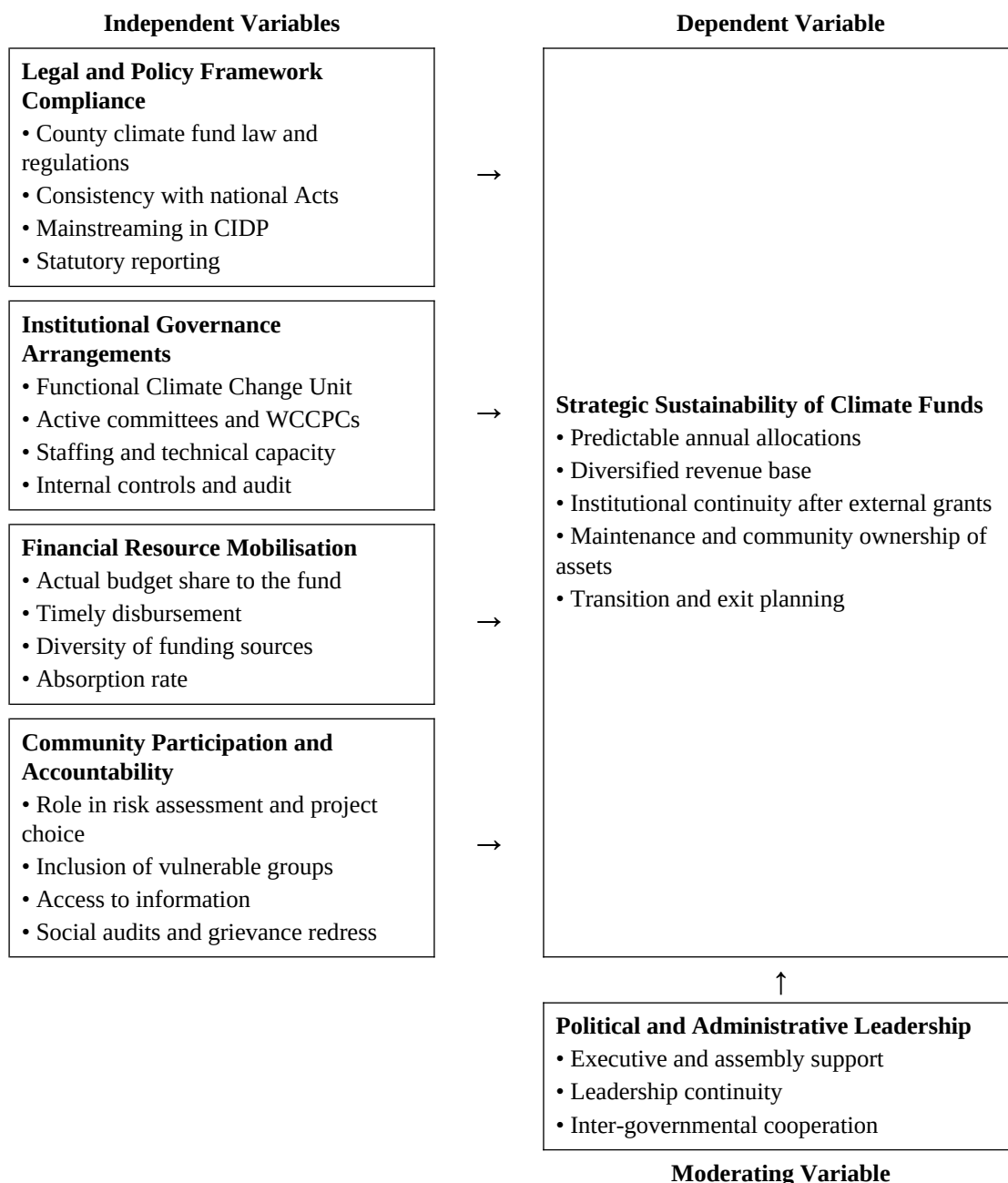
Omukuti (2020a) examined whether working through local level institutions secures country ownership that reflects the priorities of vulnerable populations. The study found that local institutions did not guarantee that local adaptation priorities were addressed: vulnerable groups often lacked voice, were excluded from participation spaces and had limited involvement, resulting in inequitable ownership. This is directly relevant to Kenya's ward climate change planning committees, which are meant to carry community voice into fund decisions.

Rahman et al. (2023) reviewed the promise and pitfalls of locally led adaptation. They argued that locally led adaptation can shift power and resources to communities, but warned of pitfalls including tokenistic participation, the reproduction of local inequalities and short-term project funding that undermines long-term local capacity. Okeke-Ogbuafor et al. (2024) evaluated existing locally led adaptation metrics relevant to Kenya's smallholder farms and developed a framework for measuring locally led adaptation in the smallholder sector. Both studies emphasise that participation must be meaningful and measurable if it is to make adaptation effective and lasting. Neither, however, linked participation directly to the financial sustainability of a county climate fund.

### **2.4 Conceptual Framework**

The conceptual framework in Figure 2.1 shows the hypothesised relationship between the independent variables, the dependent variable and the moderating variable. The independent variables are four dimensions of regulatory alignment: legal and policy

framework compliance, institutional governance arrangements, financial resource mobilisation, and community participation and accountability. The dependent variable is the strategic sustainability of the climate fund. Political and administrative leadership is expected to moderate the relationship.



**Figure 2.1: Conceptual Framework**

*Source: Researcher (2026)*

## 2.5 Summary of Literature and Research Gaps

The literature shows that Kenya has built a strong legal basis for devolved climate finance and that the county climate change fund model has delivered community-

prioritised investments in pilot counties. It also shows recurring risks: funds that depend on external support, institutions weakened by politics, uneven integration of climate change into county plans, and participation that does not always give vulnerable groups real influence. The specific gaps that this study seeks to fill are summarised in Table 2.1.

**Table 2.1: Summary of Research Gaps**

| <b>Author(s) and Year</b>                          | <b>Focus and Key Findings</b>                                                                                                            | <b>Research Gap</b>                                                                | <b>Focus of the Current Study</b>                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Crick et al. (2019)                                | Documented County Climate Change Funds in five arid pilot counties; legislation and 1–2% budget commitments institutionalised the funds. | Arid pilot counties only; no statistical test of alignment against sustainability. | Tests the influence of legal compliance on fund sustainability in a high-rainfall county. |
| Kowalczyk and Dorevitch (2024)                     | Framework for assessing adaptive capacity in County Integrated Development Plans; wide variation across counties.                        | Health sector only; plans, not budgets or funds, were analysed.                    | Assesses alignment across laws, plans, budgets and fund practice.                         |
| Shawoo et al. (2022)                               | Political factors hampered climate finance coordination in Kenya and Zambia despite country ownership.                                   | National-level coordination; county funds not examined.                            | Examines institutional governance of a county climate fund.                               |
| D'Arcy and Cornell (2016); Cheeseman et al. (2016) | Devolution shifted patronage to counties; governors became powerful collective actors.                                                   | Did not address climate finance.                                                   | Tests political and administrative leadership as a moderator.                             |
| Lutta et al. (2025); FSD Kenya (2024)              | Mapped county climate finance flows; Nandi commits 2% of development budget to climate change.                                           | Descriptive; no link to long-term sustainability.                                  | Relates resource mobilisation practices to fund sustainability.                           |
| Omukuti (2020a); Rahman et al. (2023)              | Local institutions do not guarantee voice for vulnerable groups; risk of tokenistic locally led adaptation.                              | Participation not linked to financial sustainability of a fund.                    | Tests the influence of participation and accountability on sustainability.                |

*Source: Researcher (2026)*

## **CHAPTER THREE**

### **RESEARCH METHODOLOGY**

#### **3.1 Introduction**

This chapter describes the methods that will be used to carry out the study. It covers the research design, location of the study, target population, sampling techniques and sample size, research instruments, pilot testing, data collection procedures, data analysis and ethical considerations.

#### **3.2 Research Design**

The study will adopt a convergent parallel mixed methods design. In this design, quantitative and qualitative data are collected during the same phase, analysed separately and then merged to see whether the results confirm or complement each other (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018). The quantitative strand will use a descriptive and correlational survey to measure the relationship between the dimensions of regulatory alignment and the sustainability of the climate fund. The qualitative strand will use key informant interviews and document analysis to explain how and why that relationship takes the form it does. The design suits the study because regulatory alignment has both a measurable side, such as budget allocations and compliance with reporting deadlines, and a contextual side, such as political will and the working culture of committees, that numbers alone cannot capture.

#### **3.3 Location of the Study**

The study will be conducted in Nandi County, located in the North Rift region of Kenya, with its headquarters in Kapsabet. The county borders Uasin Gishu, Kakamega, Vihiga, Kisumu and Kericho counties. It has six sub-counties and 30 wards, and a population of 885,711 (KNBS, 2019). The county was selected because it has enacted climate change fund legislation, is implementing the FLLoCA Program and has completed a ward-level participatory climate risk assessment (County Government of Nandi, 2023b; FSD Kenya, 2024), yet it has received little research attention compared to the arid pilot counties. Its dependence on climate-sensitive tea, dairy and maize farming also makes the sustainability of its climate fund important for livelihoods (MoALF, 2017).

#### **3.4 Target Population**

The target population will consist of 400 individuals directly involved in the governance and use of the Nandi County climate fund. These include officers in the Climate Change Unit and the departments responsible for environment, finance and economic planning, agriculture and water; members of the county climate change

steering and planning committees; members of the county assembly committees on environment and on budget and appropriations; members of the 30 Ward Climate Change Planning Committees; and representatives of civil society and community-based organisations engaged in climate action. The figures in Table 3.1 are estimates based on the county's institutional structure and will be confirmed from county records before sampling.

**Table 3.1: Target Population**

| Category of Respondents                                                                                                        | Target Population |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Officers of the Climate Change Unit and technical departments (environment, finance and economic planning, agriculture, water) | 46                |
| Members of county climate change steering and planning committees and fund administration                                      | 14                |
| Members of the county assembly committees on environment and on budget and appropriations                                      | 20                |
| Members of Ward Climate Change Planning Committees (30 wards × about 10 members)                                               | 300               |
| Representatives of civil society and community-based organisations                                                             | 20                |
| <b>Total</b>                                                                                                                   | <b>400</b>        |

*Source: Researcher (2026)*

### 3.5 Sampling Techniques and Sample Size

#### 3.5.1 Sample Size

The sample size will be calculated using Yamane's (1967) formula at a 95 per cent confidence level and a margin of error of 0.05:

$$n = N / (1 + N(e)^2)$$

Where n is the sample size, N is the target population (400) and e is the margin of error (0.05). Therefore,  $n = 400 / (1 + 400(0.05)^2) = 400 / 2 = 200$  respondents.

#### 3.5.2 Sampling Techniques

Proportionate stratified random sampling will be used to select survey respondents. The population will be divided into the five strata in Table 3.1, and the number of respondents drawn from each stratum will be proportional to its size. Within each stratum, respondents will be selected by simple random sampling from lists obtained from the county. For Ward Climate Change Planning Committees, respondents will be spread across all 30 wards so that every sub-county is represented. In addition, eight key informants will be purposively selected for their knowledge of the fund: the County

Executive Committee Member for environment and climate change, the Chief Officer for finance, the Climate Change Unit coordinator, the FLLoCA county focal person, the chairperson of the county assembly environment committee, the chairperson of the budget and appropriations committee, the fund administrator, and a representative of a leading civil society organisation working on climate change in the county.

**Table 3.2: Sample Size Distribution**

| Category of Respondents                                  | Population (N) | Proportion    | Sample (n) |
|----------------------------------------------------------|----------------|---------------|------------|
| Climate Change Unit and technical departments            | 46             | 11.5%         | 23         |
| Steering and planning committees and fund administration | 14             | 3.5%          | 7          |
| County assembly committee members                        | 20             | 5.0%          | 10         |
| Ward Climate Change Planning Committees                  | 300            | 75.0%         | 150        |
| Civil society and community-based organisations          | 20             | 5.0%          | 10         |
| <b>Total</b>                                             | <b>400</b>     | <b>100.0%</b> | <b>200</b> |

*Source: Researcher (2026)*

### 3.6 Research Instruments

Three instruments will be used. A structured questionnaire will collect quantitative data from the 200 respondents. It will have sections on demographic information, each of the four independent variables, the moderating variable and the dependent variable, with items measured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from strongly disagree (1) to strongly agree (5). A key informant interview guide will collect in-depth qualitative data from the eight key informants. A document analysis checklist will be used to review the county climate change fund legislation and regulations, the County Integrated Development Plan 2023–2027, the county climate change action plan, annual budgets and budget implementation reports, audit reports and FLLoCA annual performance assessment reports. The checklist will include a regulatory alignment matrix that scores each county instrument against the relevant provisions of the Climate Change Act, 2016 (as amended), the Public Finance Management Act, 2012 and the County Governments Act, 2012. Table 3.3 shows how the variables will be operationalised.

**Table 3.3: Operationalisation of Study Variables**

| Variable                                                 | Indicators                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Measurement                                     | Analysis                                              |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Legal and policy framework compliance (independent)      | Existence and currency of county climate change fund law and regulations; consistency with Climate Change Act, 2016 (as amended) and PFM Act, 2012; mainstreaming in CIDP and annual plans; timeliness of statutory reports | Five-point Likert scale; alignment matrix score | Descriptive statistics, correlation, regression       |
| Institutional governance arrangements (independent)      | Functionality of Climate Change Unit and committees; staffing and skills; clarity of roles; frequency of meetings; internal controls and audit                                                                              | Five-point Likert scale                         | Descriptive statistics, correlation, regression       |
| Financial resource mobilisation (independent)            | Actual share of development budget allocated; timeliness of disbursement; number and share of funding sources; own-source revenue contribution; absorption rate                                                             | Five-point Likert scale; budget ratios          | Descriptive statistics, trend analysis, regression    |
| Community participation and accountability (independent) | Involvement in risk assessment and project selection; representation of women, youth and vulnerable groups; access to information; social audits; grievance redress                                                         | Five-point Likert scale                         | Descriptive statistics, correlation, regression       |
| Political and administrative leadership (moderating)     | Executive and assembly support for the fund; continuity of leadership; inter-governmental cooperation                                                                                                                       | Five-point Likert scale                         | Moderated multiple regression                         |
| Strategic sustainability of climate funds (dependent)    | Predictability of annual allocations; diversity of revenue; continuity of institutions after external grants; maintenance and community ownership of assets; existence of a transition plan                                 | Five-point Likert scale; document evidence      | Descriptive statistics, regression, thematic analysis |

Source: Researcher (2026)

### 3.7 Pilot Testing

The questionnaire and interview guide will be pre-tested in neighbouring Uasin Gishu County, which also participates in the FLLoCA Program and shares similar agro-ecological characteristics. Twenty respondents, representing ten per cent of the sample, will take part in the pilot study, in line with the recommendation of Mugenda and Mugenda (2003). Respondents in the pilot will not take part in the main study.

### **3.7.1 Validity of Research Instruments**

Content validity will be established by asking the university supervisors and two experts in climate finance and public finance to rate the relevance of each item to the study objectives. A Content Validity Index (CVI) will be computed, and items with a CVI below 0.70 will be revised or removed. Construct validity will be supported by basing each item on the theories and empirical studies reviewed in Chapter Two. Triangulation of questionnaire, interview and documentary data will further strengthen the credibility of the findings.

### **3.7.2 Reliability of Research Instruments**

Reliability of the questionnaire will be tested using Cronbach's alpha coefficient, which measures the internal consistency of items in a scale (Cronbach, 1951). A coefficient of 0.70 and above will be considered acceptable. Items that lower the coefficient of their scale will be reviewed before the main data collection. For the qualitative instruments, dependability will be enhanced by keeping an audit trail of interview notes, transcripts and coding decisions.

## **3.8 Data Collection Procedures**

After approval of the proposal, the researcher will obtain an introduction letter from Mount Kenya University, a research permit from the National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation (NACOSTI) and authorisation from the County Government of Nandi and the County Commissioner. Three research assistants will be recruited and trained on the instruments and research ethics. Questionnaires will be administered through the drop-and-pick-later method for county officials and in person, with assistance where needed, for ward committee members. Key informant interviews will be conducted by the researcher at a time and place convenient to each informant, will last about 45 minutes, and will be audio-recorded with consent. Documents will be obtained from the county's official website, the Controller of Budget, the Office of the Auditor-General and the county climate change unit.

## **3.9 Data Analysis and Presentation**

Quantitative data will be checked for completeness, coded and entered into the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) version 27. Descriptive statistics, namely frequencies, percentages, means and standard deviations, will summarise the responses. Pearson's correlation coefficient will measure the strength and direction of the relationship between each independent variable and the dependent variable. Multiple linear regression will then be used to test hypotheses H01 to H04, using the following model:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_1 + \beta_2 X_2 + \beta_3 X_3 + \beta_4 X_4 + \varepsilon$$

Where Y is the strategic sustainability of the climate fund; X<sub>1</sub> is legal and policy framework compliance; X<sub>2</sub> is institutional governance arrangements; X<sub>3</sub> is financial resource mobilisation; X<sub>4</sub> is community participation and accountability; β<sub>0</sub> is the constant; β<sub>1</sub> to β<sub>4</sub> are the regression coefficients; and ε is the error term. To test H05, moderated multiple regression will be used, in which a composite regulatory alignment index (X) and the moderator, political and administrative leadership (M), and their interaction term (XM) are entered in successive steps:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X + \beta_2 M + \beta_3 (X \times M) + \varepsilon$$

Moderation will be confirmed if the interaction term is statistically significant and the change in R<sup>2</sup> is significant. Before regression, the data will be tested for normality, linearity, multicollinearity and homoscedasticity. Qualitative data from interviews will be transcribed and analysed thematically following the six phases described by Braun and Clarke (2006), with the help of NVivo software. Documents will be analysed using the regulatory alignment matrix, and trends in climate fund allocations and absorption will be computed from budget and expenditure reports for 2021/2022 to 2025/2026. Findings will be presented in tables, charts and narrative form, and quantitative and qualitative results will be integrated during interpretation.

### 3.10 Ethical Considerations

The study will be conducted in line with the research ethics guidelines of Mount Kenya University. Ethical clearance will be sought from the University's ethics review committee, and a research permit will be obtained from NACOSTI. Participation will be voluntary, and every respondent will be informed of the purpose of the study and will sign an informed consent form. Respondents will be free to withdraw at any stage without penalty. Questionnaires will not record names, and interview data will be anonymised using codes. Data will be stored in password-protected files and used only for academic purposes. All sources consulted will be acknowledged using the APA 7th edition referencing style to avoid plagiarism, and the final work will be subjected to a similarity check.

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## APPENDICES

### Appendix I: Work Plan

| Activity                               | Timeline       |
|----------------------------------------|----------------|
| Concept paper development and approval | Sep – Oct 2026 |
| Proposal writing and supervision       | Oct – Dec 2026 |
| Proposal defence and corrections       | Jan 2027       |
| Ethical clearance and NACOSTI permit   | Feb 2027       |
| Pilot study and instrument revision    | Mar 2027       |
| Data collection                        | Apr – May 2027 |
| Data analysis                          | Jun 2027       |
| Thesis writing and supervision         | Jul – Aug 2027 |
| Thesis submission and defence          | Sep 2027       |

### Appendix II: Research Budget

| Item                                                             | Amount (KES)   |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| Stationery, printing and binding                                 | 15,000         |
| Internet, data bundles and airtime                               | 10,000         |
| NACOSTI research permit and ethical review                       | 6,000          |
| Pilot study (travel and materials)                               | 15,000         |
| Training and remuneration of three research assistants           | 60,000         |
| Travel and subsistence during data collection (six sub-counties) | 55,000         |
| Refreshments for respondents and key informants                  | 10,000         |
| Data analysis software and transcription                         | 20,000         |
| Thesis typesetting, printing and binding                         | 15,000         |
| Contingency (about 10 per cent)                                  | 20,600         |
| <b>Total</b>                                                     | <b>226,600</b> |